sanctioned a winner-takes-all match against the so-called Stanford Superstars.

That was a West Indies team, selected by a panel overseen by Viv Richards. They prepared in Antigua under coaches Eldine Baptiste and Roger Harper. It was so disciplinarian that no-balls in the nets drew a fine. According to the late and legendary cricket writer Tony Cozier, one player, opening batsman Xavier Marshall, was dropped after failing a drugs test through his smoking marijuana.

I don't think performance-enhancing drugs are especially common in cricket, by the way, though the advantages of, say, a fast bowler building muscle mass are obvious. During the course of a year hair samples would be taken from the England team twice, as part of a programme to test for recreational drugs. Urine samples were taken randomly six or seven times a year to test for performance-enhancing drugs. You can always do more, I suppose, but that seemed adequate.

Going back to Stanford, some leading figures in West Indian cricket, including Michael Holding, Clive Lloyd, Desmond Haynes and Ian Bishop, opted out, sensing it was too good to be true. Yet the fraudster's bluster and ambition swayed good judges like Mark Nicholas, who, according to Tony Cozier, observed that 'Stanford's calypso cricket revolution might just save the game's fall from grace'.

It was surreal, extraordinary. I wasn't at Lord's for his arrival, but watched on TV, as fascinated as the rest. It felt like a significant event, a little like the Packer breakaway must have felt in the seventies. Life-changing sums were being talked about, and it captured the spirit of the times as part of the advent of franchised cricket. The IPL was coming on stream, and players were starting to get itchy feet.

Obviously, Stanford's scheme was fundamentally flawed, given his subsequent conviction for orchestrating a $7 billion Ponzi scheme. He's serving a 110-year sentence in a federal penitentiary in Florida. We were called England but, as players, objected to the connotations of the title. Playing for your country is an honour, a special thing that should not be for sale. We had no say in it, and it didn't feel right.

The event itself was a circus, a shambles. We stumbled into the unknown. The match was staged next to Antigua airport, in a stadium Stanford named after himself when he funded renovations. It has now reverted to its original